

Chapter 7: Modals

Modals are helping verbs that express ability, permission, possibility, obligation, and necessity. They are used with the base form of the main verb. Modals do not change according to subject and tense forms.

Rules for Using Modals

Modals are followed by the base form of the verb. They do not take 's', 'es', or 'ed'. Questions are formed by placing the modal before the subject. Negatives are formed by adding 'not' after the modal. Two modals are not used together. Modals show the speaker's attitude or mood. They help convey meaning clearly.

Can

Ability, permission, or possibility in the present. It is informal and common in speech. It is also used in requests. It does not change with subject. It is easy to identify. It is widely used in daily communication.

Examples:

- She can swim.
- Can I go out?
- He can solve this problem.
- I can hear you.
- They can play well.

Could

Past ability and polite requests. It expresses possibility. It is softer than can. It is used in conditional sentences. It shows uncertainty. It is polite in tone.

Examples:

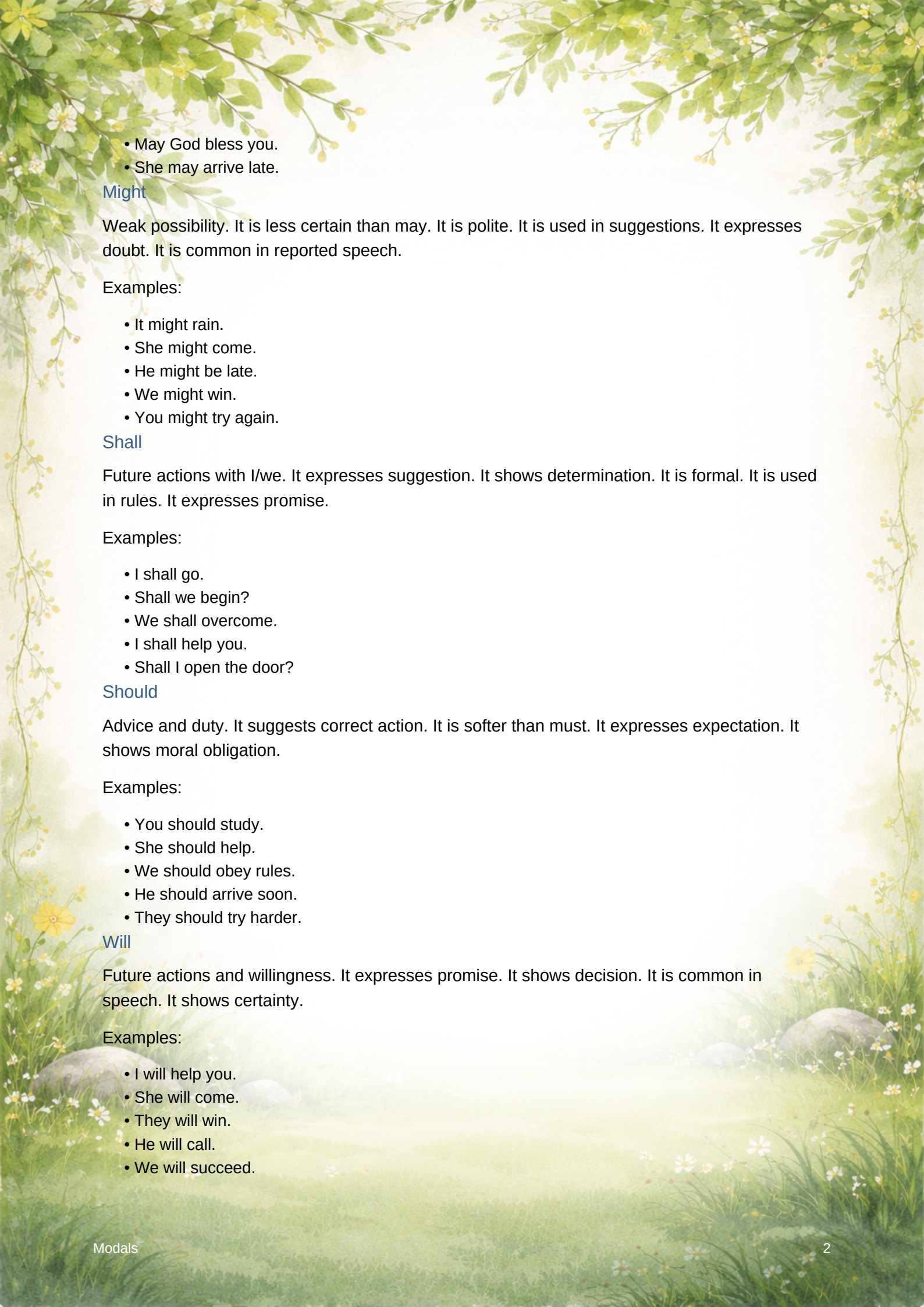
- She could swim.
- Could you help me?
- It could rain.
- He could run fast.
- We could try again.

May

Permission and possibility. It is formal. It is used in official language. It shows uncertainty. It expresses wishes. It sounds polite.

Examples:

- May I come in?
- It may rain today.
- You may leave now.

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- May God bless you.
 - She may arrive late.

Might

Weak possibility. It is less certain than may. It is polite. It is used in suggestions. It expresses doubt. It is common in reported speech.

Examples:

- It might rain.
- She might come.
- He might be late.
- We might win.
- You might try again.

Shall

Future actions with I/we. It expresses suggestion. It shows determination. It is formal. It is used in rules. It expresses promise.

Examples:

- I shall go.
- Shall we begin?
- We shall overcome.
- I shall help you.
- Shall I open the door?

Should

Advice and duty. It suggests correct action. It is softer than must. It expresses expectation. It shows moral obligation.

Examples:

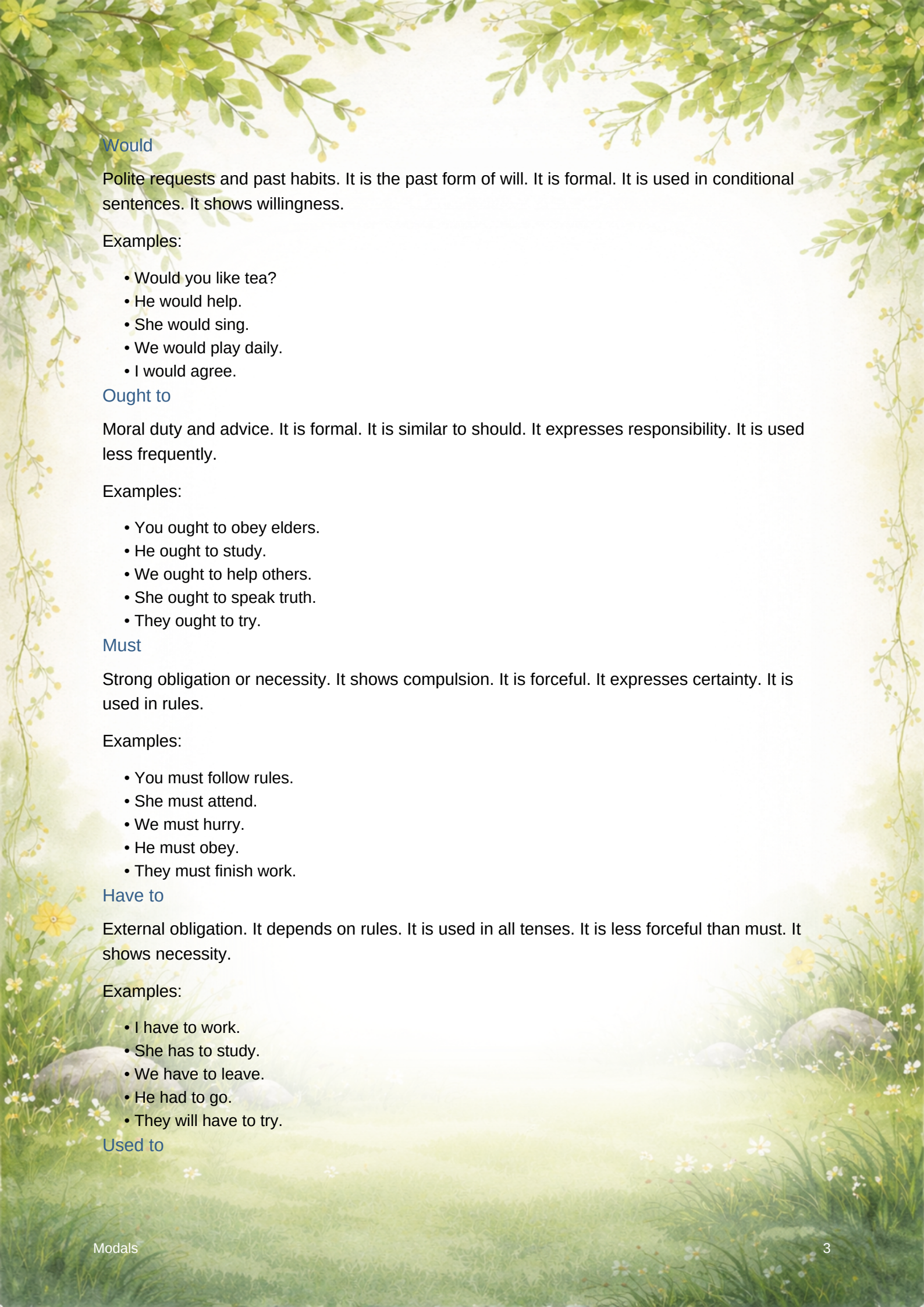
- You should study.
- She should help.
- We should obey rules.
- He should arrive soon.
- They should try harder.

Will

Future actions and willingness. It expresses promise. It shows decision. It is common in speech. It shows certainty.

Examples:

- I will help you.
- She will come.
- They will win.
- He will call.
- We will succeed.



Would

Polite requests and past habits. It is the past form of will. It is formal. It is used in conditional sentences. It shows willingness.

Examples:

- Would you like tea?
- He would help.
- She would sing.
- We would play daily.
- I would agree.

Ought to

Moral duty and advice. It is formal. It is similar to should. It expresses responsibility. It is used less frequently.

Examples:

- You ought to obey elders.
- He ought to study.
- We ought to help others.
- She ought to speak truth.
- They ought to try.

Must

Strong obligation or necessity. It shows compulsion. It is forceful. It expresses certainty. It is used in rules.

Examples:

- You must follow rules.
- She must attend.
- We must hurry.
- He must obey.
- They must finish work.

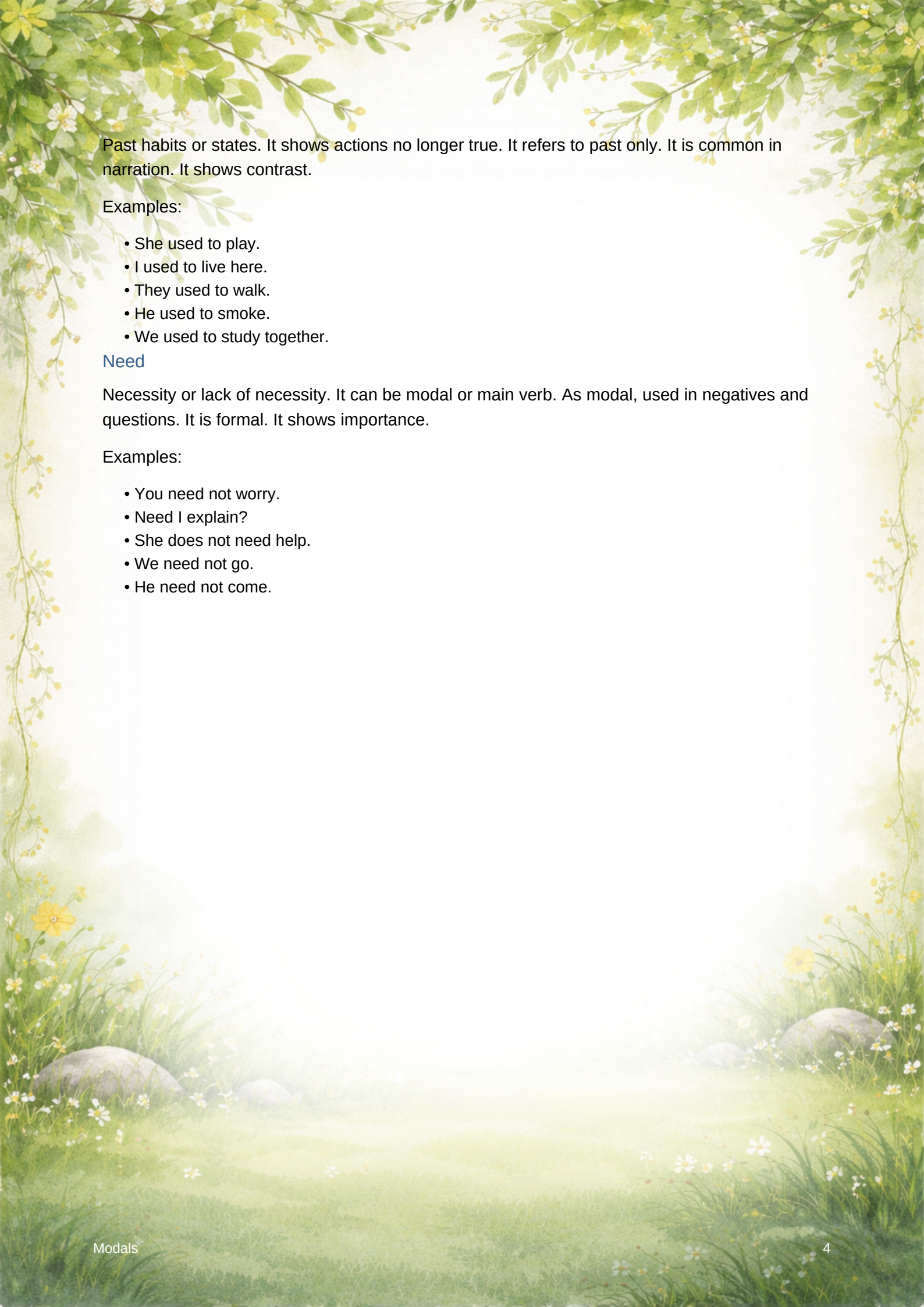
Have to

External obligation. It depends on rules. It is used in all tenses. It is less forceful than must. It shows necessity.

Examples:

- I have to work.
- She has to study.
- We have to leave.
- He had to go.
- They will have to try.

Used to



Past habits or states. It shows actions no longer true. It refers to past only. It is common in narration. It shows contrast.

Examples:

- She used to play.
- I used to live here.
- They used to walk.
- He used to smoke.
- We used to study together.

Need

Necessity or lack of necessity. It can be modal or main verb. As modal, used in negatives and questions. It is formal. It shows importance.

Examples:

- You need not worry.
- Need I explain?
- She does not need help.
- We need not go.
- He need not come.

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify the modal

- She can solve the problem.
- You should respect elders.
- He must finish work.
- May I come in?
- They will arrive soon.

Exercise 2: Fill in the blanks

- You _____ obey rules.
- _____ I use your pen?
- She _____ complete today.
- We _____ go tomorrow.
- He _____ not speak loudly.

Exercise 3: Choose the correct modal

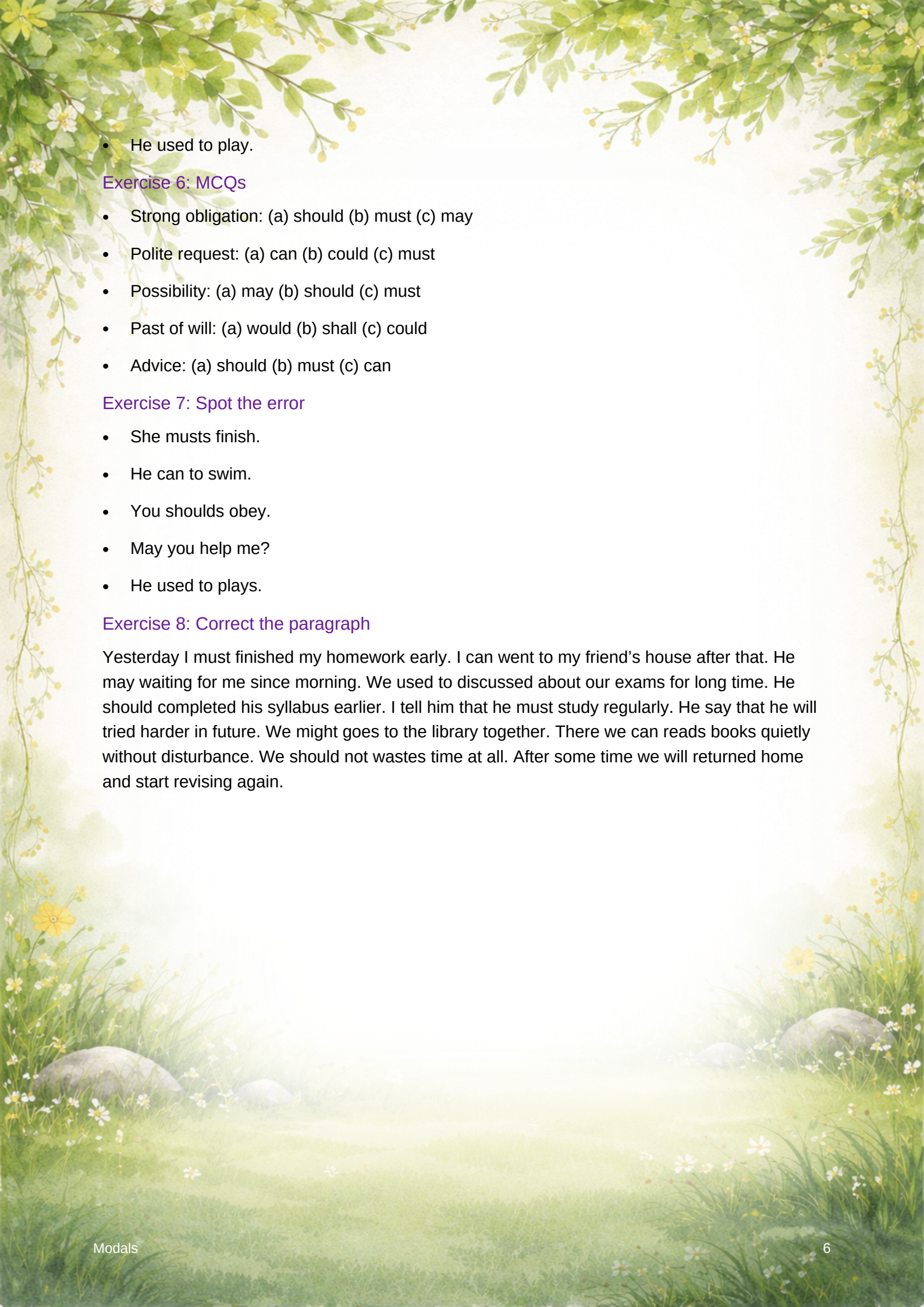
- You (must/may) follow rules.
- (Can/Might) you help me?
- It (will/might) rain.
- We (should/must) respect teachers.
- She (used to/use to) live here.

Exercise 4: Match the following

can	ability
should	advice
must	obligation
may	permission

Exercise 5: Identify types

- She must complete work.
- Can you swim?
- You should speak politely.
- It may snow.

- 
- He used to play.

Exercise 6: MCQs

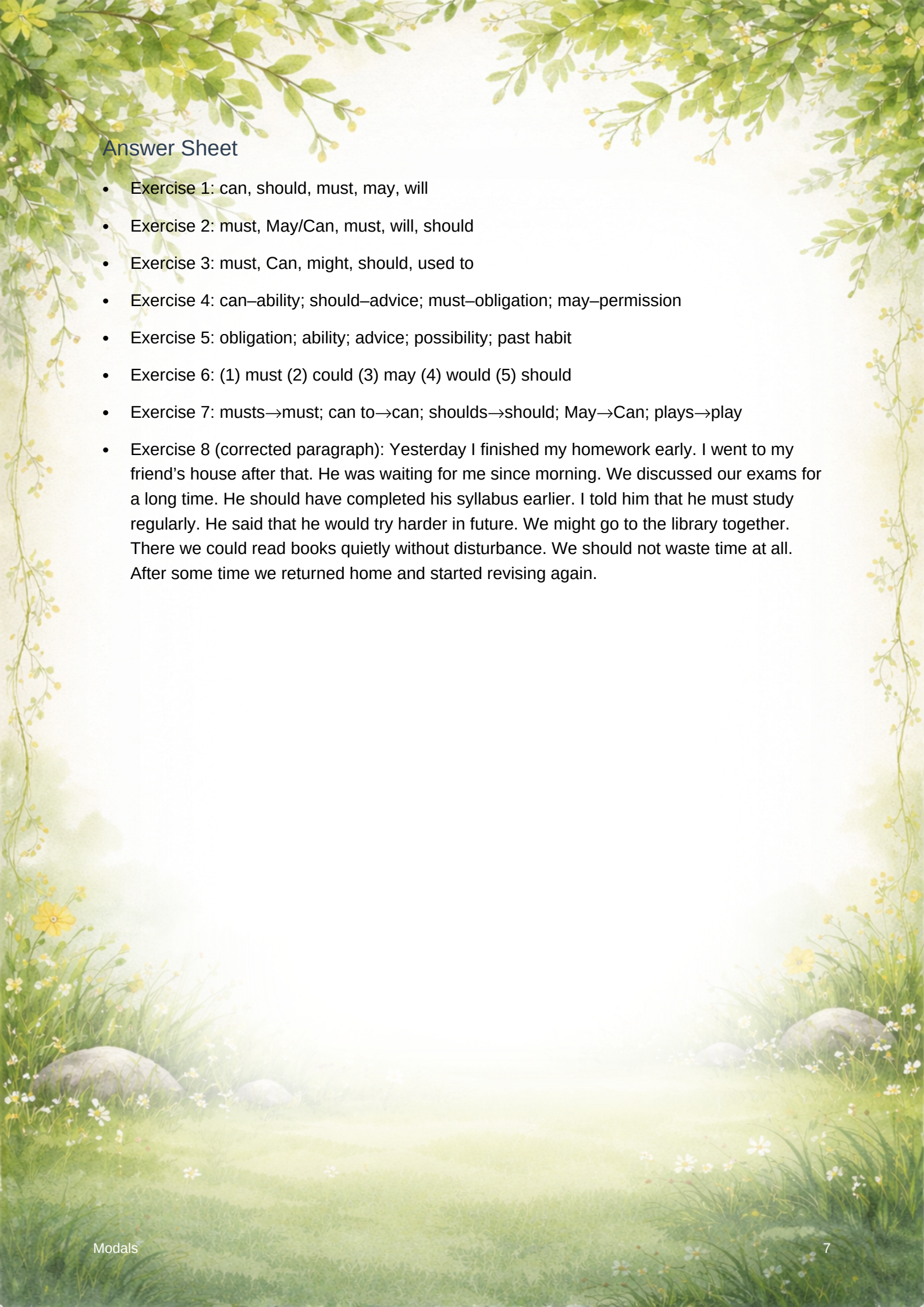
- Strong obligation: (a) should (b) must (c) may
- Polite request: (a) can (b) could (c) must
- Possibility: (a) may (b) should (c) must
- Past of will: (a) would (b) shall (c) could
- Advice: (a) should (b) must (c) can

Exercise 7: Spot the error

- She musts finish.
- He can to swim.
- You shoulds obey.
- May you help me?
- He used to plays.

Exercise 8: Correct the paragraph

Yesterday I must finished my homework early. I can went to my friend's house after that. He may waiting for me since morning. We used to discussed about our exams for long time. He should completed his syllabus earlier. I tell him that he must study regularly. He say that he will tried harder in future. We might goes to the library together. There we can reads books quietly without disturbance. We should not wastes time at all. After some time we will returned home and start revising again.



Answer Sheet

- Exercise 1: can, should, must, may, will
- Exercise 2: must, May/Can, must, will, should
- Exercise 3: must, Can, might, should, used to
- Exercise 4: can—ability; should—advice; must—obligation; may—permission
- Exercise 5: obligation; ability; advice; possibility; past habit
- Exercise 6: (1) must (2) could (3) may (4) would (5) should
- Exercise 7: musts→must; can to→can; shoulds→should; May→Can; plays→play
- Exercise 8 (corrected paragraph): Yesterday I finished my homework early. I went to my friend's house after that. He was waiting for me since morning. We discussed our exams for a long time. He should have completed his syllabus earlier. I told him that he must study regularly. He said that he would try harder in future. We might go to the library together. There we could read books quietly without disturbance. We should not waste time at all. After some time we returned home and started revising again.